



GAME-SPECIFIC FACULTY GUIDE

Room to Stay

A city-management simulation built around rent ceilings and housing access.

Why This Game Exists

Room to Stay was the first game in this series. In designing it, I wanted students to make housing-policy decisions before showing them the supply-and-demand graph underneath those decisions. They enter Linden after the city has already imposed a rent ceiling. Their job is to deal with what happens next.

Students can learn that a binding price ceiling creates a shortage without understanding life inside it. In Linden, applicants wait, owners face repair bills, and developers weigh potential projects. Tenants need help now; construction takes time. By the time the graph appears, students have managed the shortage it describes.

What Students Do

Students take the role Housing advisor · City of Linden. A run takes about 10–15 minutes, with six decisions across two years. They inherit a binding rent ceiling covering existing rentals and future projects. At this rent below equilibrium, more households seek apartments and fewer units are offered.

Students allocate scarce vacancies in Month 1, then address maintenance through inspections, grants, or phased requirements in Month 6. Month 9 turns to density and permit reform, co-funded apartments, construction exemptions, or existing development limits. Those commitments carry forward as students weigh incumbent security against newcomer search assistance in Month 12, reconsider rental aid in Month 18, and set an access or stability priority in Month 24.

Earlier choices affect later options, and commitments that use budget room can limit what the city can do later.

Each choice brings consequences, indicator changes, and an economic tradeoff. At the end, students review their path, a four-part explanation, alternatives, and Read the rent ceiling, a schematic graph with three application questions.

Five indicators track Renter affordability (relief for current renters), Housing availability (access for people seeking a home), Housing quality, Budget room, and Construction incentive. These bounded ordinal conditions run from 0 to 8; higher means more of the named condition, not dollars or percentages. Linden is an instructional model, and its compressed two-year sequence offers no empirical forecast. Use the written consequences to explain changes.

What the Game Is Really Teaching

Students arrive in a city where a covered apartment costs less but is harder to obtain. At the controlled rent, quantity demanded has risen and quantity supplied has fallen: Q_d exceeds Q_s . Applicants search for homes that many other households also want. A vacancy lottery makes allocation more transparent and less dependent on connections, while leaving the number of apartments unchanged. Someone must still wait.

Exempting new leases offers another response. Owners become more willing to offer vacancies, and newcomers encounter market rents on those leases. Existing covered tenants retain their protection. The choice changes both incentives and payment burdens. Linden tracks affordability and availability separately because relief for a tenant who already holds a lease can coexist with a difficult search for someone entering the market.

The next decision takes students inside the buildings. Repair costs have risen, and controlled revenue limits some owners' ability to recover them. Inspections hold quality steady in the model, but some marginal units leave rental use when owners face required repairs. Conditional grants help owners maintain existing homes and keep them available, at a larger public cost. Phasing requirements preserves funds while deferred work accumulates. Ask students whose constraint their response addressed and who carried the remaining cost.

Developers then bring a different clock into the story. Easing density limits and permit delays makes more projects feasible; construction support helps finance mixed-rent homes; an exemption improves expected returns on new buildings. Each can start a pipeline. Tenants still need somewhere to live while builders work. Permit reform produces a smaller later response when new units remain controlled, showing how the student's earlier lease decision interacts with the supply decision. Repairing an existing home improves its condition; adding housing requires that separate building process.

While projects proceed, protected tenants and newcomers face different problems. Stronger renewal protection lowers incumbents' displacement risk and leaves fewer openings through turnover. Application and relocation help uses city funds to ease outsiders' searches, with the housing stock unchanged. A tenant may gain security, an applicant may gain help navigating vacancies, and a newcomer with an exempt lease may gain access at a higher rent.

Rental assistance addresses the payment problem for eligible households. Broader aid provides more relief and uses more budget room; temporary eviction-prevention grants reach a narrower group. Tapering aid restores some fiscal flexibility while recipients must cover more of their costs. Controlled apartments remain rationed, and extra purchasing power may put upward pressure on rents in exempt segments. These choices can help people even while the shortage persists. Their opportunity cost appears in the other uses the city gives up for its limited funds.

At the two-year review, earlier supply choices can finally deliver homes. The final priority shapes access and support as those projects open. A construction subsidy may also fund investment that would have occurred anyway, so spending and additional housing cannot be treated as equivalent. The closing explanation brings together the shortage, maintenance and future supply, distribution and affordability, and fiscal cost and timing. Students' decision histories help explain how these mechanisms interacted.

Reading the Changing City

The recurring neighborhood gives students visual evidence to discuss alongside the text. The opening queue makes limited vacancies visible. Later, a crane and unfinished building can appear while applicants still wait. Compare that scene with completed housing and ask what had to happen between the two.



Construction underway, left, and completed homes, right. Encouraging investment takes time to become housing people can occupy.

Deferred-maintenance imagery brings quality pressure into the discussion. Construction shows future supply while applicants still wait; completed homes show that supply arriving. Ask students to connect each scene to their choices and the written consequences, then explain whose circumstances changed.

The Educational Loop

City decisions lead to consequences and explanations. The closing debrief and graph formalize the experience; three applications extend it to rationing, access, and additional construction. Feedback and retries support those applications, and replay lets students investigate another policy path.

Experience → Consequence → Economic Explanation → Formalization → Transfer

Bringing in the Supply-and-Demand Graph

Build the diagram from students' experience, or discuss the game's Read the rent ceiling graph. For a class reveal first, ask them to pause at the outcome before scrolling to that section.

1. Ask what condition existed when students arrived in Linden. Establish that they inherited the binding ceiling after the vote.
2. Put rent on the vertical axis and rental units on the horizontal axis. Draw supply and demand, then mark equilibrium rent P_e and quantity Q_e .
3. Add the ceiling P_c below P_e . At P_c , read Q_s from supply and Q_d from demand. Show that $Q_d > Q_s$ and mark the shortage $Q_d - Q_s$ between them.
4. Ask where students encountered that gap: long searches, scarce vacancies, the lottery, or different experiences for incumbents and newcomers.
5. Sort later decisions by what they addressed: current allocation, existing quality, payment relief, future supply, distribution, or public spending. Some belong in more than one category.
6. Discuss how earlier construction decisions can support a later supply response. Ask why apartments underway were unavailable to tenants and how exemptions changed developers' incentives.

The built-in graph depicts the initial controlled market. It has no measured Linden quantities and does not plot the final market after exemptions or mitigation. Keep any later supply sketch schematic; the five indicators cannot supply precise graph coordinates.

Using It in Class

These are possible starting points; choose what fits your course.

Before formal price-ceiling instruction

Let students run Linden before introducing the graph. Ask what problems kept recurring, then build the diagram from their accounts. The introduction already identifies the ceiling and shortage; the experience-first sequence delays the formal graph.

During or after instruction

Ask where $Q_d > Q_s$ appears in the story, how vacancies are allocated, and how earlier choices affect later ones. Endings reflect accumulated choices: funding stress can accompany different housing outcomes. Have students read Your path alongside What changed overall to explain that combination. The endings are unranked, with no universally preferred policy package.

Comparison and replay

Record the first ending, predict the effect of changing one decision, and use Replay scenario. Compare both histories and all five indicators. Ask what changed and which economic consequence followed. Earlier decisions may also alter later options. Treat replay as a counterfactual investigation, explaining different outcomes without searching for a winning path.

Independent/student review

Students can complete the simulation, debrief, and applications independently. Request an ending screenshot and a short explanation through your course workflow. The game provides no automatic faculty report.

Questions to Consider

Select any of these prompts for discussion or a short reflection.

1. The ceiling lowers the rent on a covered apartment. Why does that fail to guarantee a home for every applicant? Use an example from Linden.
2. Where did you encounter the shortage before seeing the graph? Locate that experience between Q_s and Q_d at the controlled rent.
3. How does the vacancy lottery change allocation, and what happens to the underlying shortage when the ceiling and curves stay fixed?
4. How did your lease or renewal decision affect incumbent tenants and newcomers differently? Identify changes in payments, security, or opportunities to enter.
5. Compare inspections, conditional repair grants, and phased requirements. Who bears the cost, and how do quality and availability respond?
6. Why can the city encourage construction without improving availability immediately? Trace a supply decision through the two-year review, including the role of rent exemptions.
7. Which commitment used public budget room without directly adding apartments? What problem did it address, and what other use of funds did you give up?
8. Which decision would you change on replay? Predict the mechanism, then explain whether the second path supports your prediction.

Common Misconceptions

- “Lower rent means housing is easier to obtain.” A covered tenant can receive payment relief while newcomers compete for scarce vacancies. Compare the affordability and availability indicators.
- “A vacancy lottery eliminates the shortage.” It changes who receives available homes. With the ceiling and curves unchanged, Q_d still exceeds Q_s .
- “Repair grants and rental assistance both add apartments.” Repair grants improve existing housing; assistance helps eligible renters pay. Ask which decision actually created a construction pipeline.
- “Housing under construction already counts as available.” Tenants gain access when homes open. Use the two scenes to trace the lag.
- “Stronger tenant protection helps every housing seeker equally.” Renewal security helps covered incumbents while fewer turnover vacancies can extend newcomers’ searches.
- “One ending is the correct solution.” Each history combines relief, access, quality, incentives, and fiscal costs. Explain those consequences before evaluating the priorities behind them.

General teaching and implementation resources are available at [Mastery Quests Faculty Resources](#).